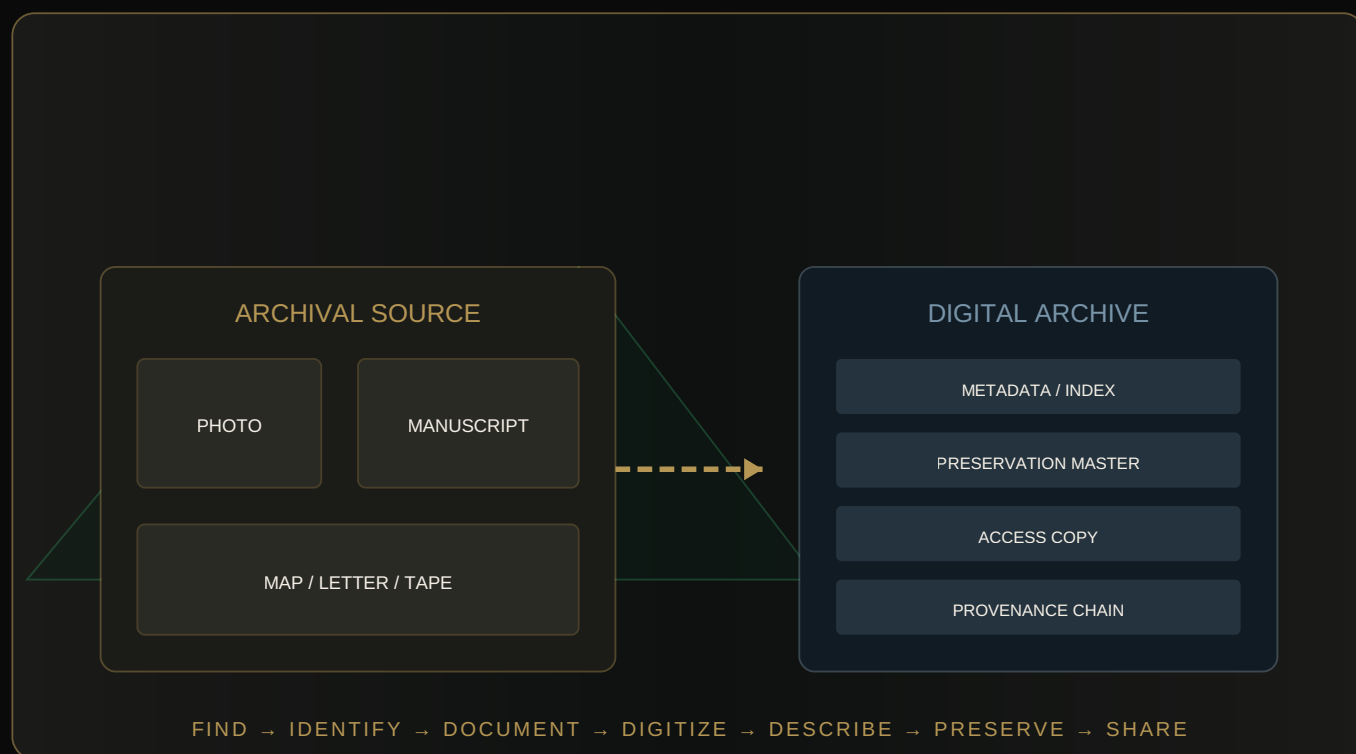


DIGITIZING TRIBAL ARCHIVES

“From fragile records to carefully preserved memory.”



Digitizing Tribal Archives: Transforming vulnerable historical records into structured, preserved resources for future generations.

“An archive does not always begin in an archive building. Sometimes it begins in a wooden box. A photograph kept inside a family cupboard. A handwritten genealogy. An old letter. A land document. A school certificate. A religious manuscript. A cassette recording. A newspaper clipping. A map folded for decades. Or the memory of an elder who knows where an important document was once kept.

For communities whose histories have often been recorded by outsiders, preserving locally held records can add another dimension to the historical record. But digitization must be approached carefully. The first responsibility is

not to publish. It is to understand what the record is, who owns it, where it came from, what it contains, and who should be allowed to access it. Only then can technology help transform vulnerable records into preserved historical resources.”

WHAT IS A TRIBAL ARCHIVE?

There is no single universal definition of a "tribal archive." In the context of Orakzai history, the term describes a diverse range of historically significant records held by families, community institutions, religious bodies, and government archives. These records are not standardized and require specific cultural and ethical considerations during digitization.

Diverse Archival Record: FAMILY + COMMUNITY + RELIGIOUS + LOCAL + INSTITUTIONAL + GOVERNMENT + DIASPORA

ORAKZAI ARCHIVAL LANDSCAPE

Historical evidence relating to Orakzai communities is distributed across various institutions rather than a single central repository. Official state records, colonial documents, and academic research coexist with private family collections and oral histories. Digitization connects these fragments without requiring the physical transfer of originals. We distinguish between **Primary vs Secondary** sources to assess historical reliability.

ARCHIVAL ETHICS AND SENSITIVITY

Digitization does not automatically make a record public or authentic. It does not transfer ownership or erase cultural sensitivity. Ethical archiving requires informed consent, especially for private correspondence, religious material, or records involving living individuals. Access levels (Open, Limited, Restricted, Private) must be determined based on privacy, copyright, and community sovereignty.

ARCHIVAL CLAIM MATRIX

Claim	Archive/Material	Evidence	Source	Confidence
Diverse Holdings	Family/ Community	UCLA MEAP records	UCLA (2024)	High
Community Sovereignty	Metadata Practices	"Metadata as Radical Care"	ResearchGate (2024)	High

Claim	Archive/Material	Evidence	Source	Confidence
Safeguarding Principles	Documentary Heritage	UNESCO General Guidelines	UNESCO (2002)	High
Provenance Chain	Digital Preservation	ICA/DPC Standards	DPC (2025)	High

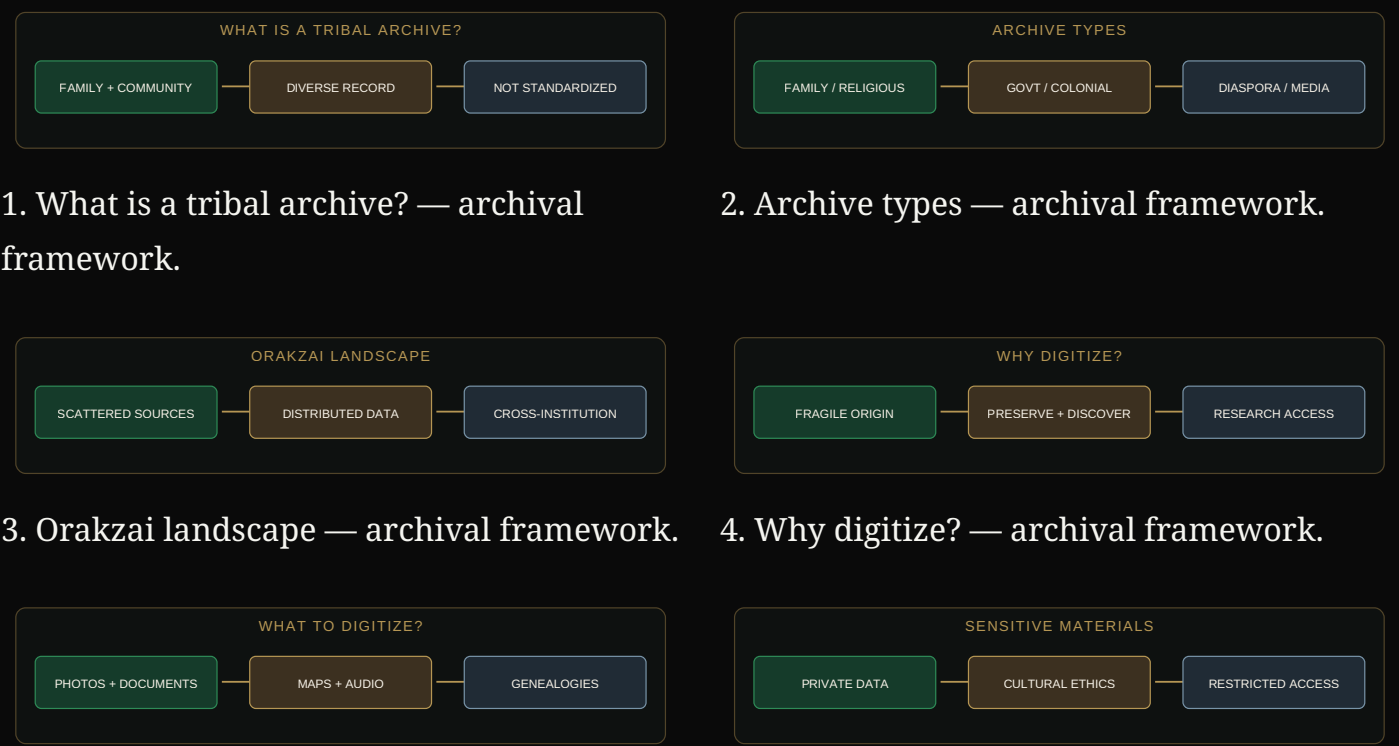
DIGITIZATION WORKFLOW

A responsible workflow involves: 1. Survey, 2. Identify, 3. Consent, 4. Prepare, 5. Capture, 6. Quality Control, 7. Metadata, 8. Preservation Master, 9. Backup, and 10. Access. We follow the **3-2-1 Backup Rule** (3 copies, 2 media types, 1 offsite) for digital resilience. Documenting the **Provenance** (Creator → Owner → Custodian → Digitizer) and the **Chain of Custody** is essential for assessing a record's historical value.

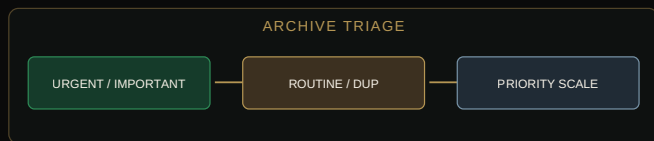
AI AND ARCHIVE ASSISTANCE

AI tools can assist in OCR for Perso-Arabic scripts, transcription, and metadata tagging. However, AI is an assistant, not an authority. We do not automatically assume AI output is correct. AI-generated text is not evidence of historical truth. Human review is the final authority to ensure authenticity and prevent the fabrication of history. We do not claim that technology can independently preserve culture; evidence is limited regarding AI's ability to capture deep cultural context.

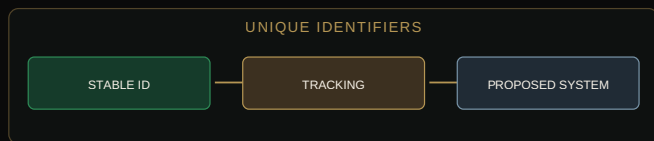
LOGIC ATLAS: DIGITIZING ARCHIVES



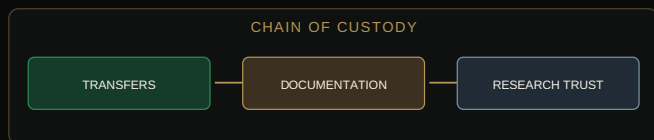
5. What to digitize? — archival framework.



7. Archive triage — archival framework.



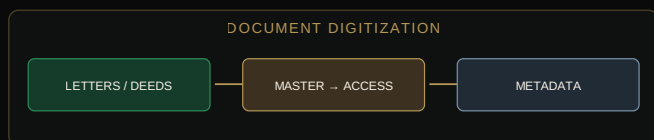
9. Unique identifiers — archival framework.



11. Chain of custody — archival framework.



13. Original material — archival framework.



15. Document digitization — archival framework.



17. Pashto/Perso-Arabic — archival framework.

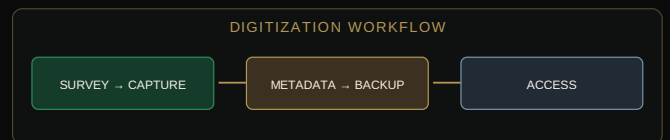
6. Sensitive materials — archival framework.



8. Collection survey — archival framework.



10. Provenance — archival framework.



12. Digitization workflow — archival framework.



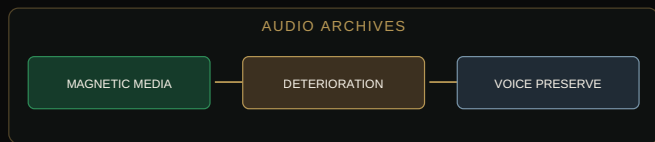
14. Photograph digitization — archival framework.



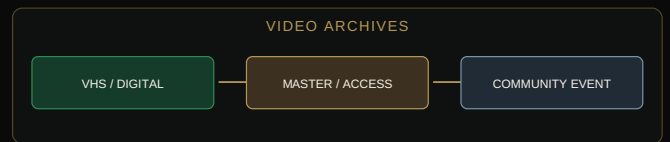
16. Manuscripts — archival framework.



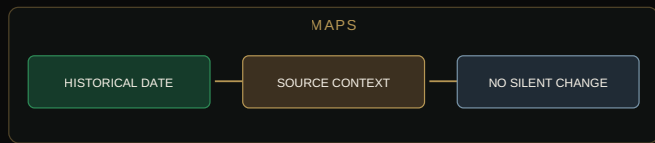
18. OCR — archival framework.



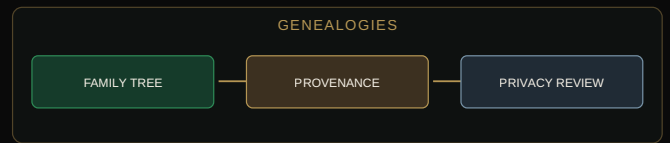
19. Audio archives — archival framework.



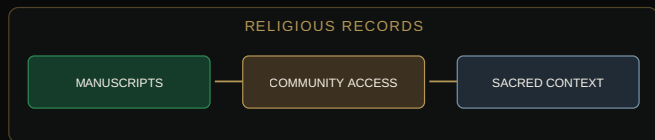
20. Video archives — archival framework.



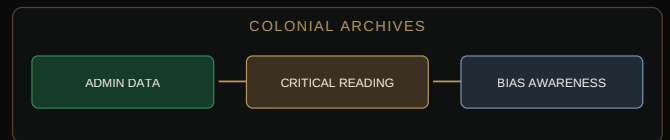
21. Maps — archival framework.



22. Genealogies — archival framework.



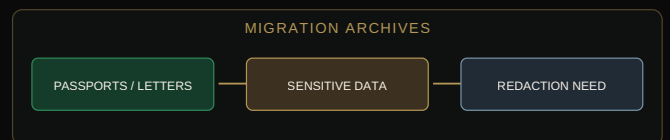
23. Religious records — archival framework.



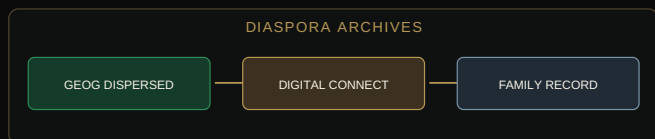
24. Colonial archives — archival framework.



25. Post-1947 records — archival framework.



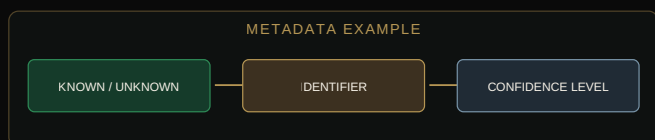
26. Migration archives — archival framework.



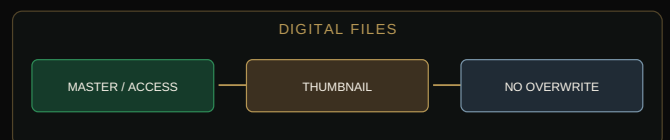
27. Diaspora archives — archival framework.



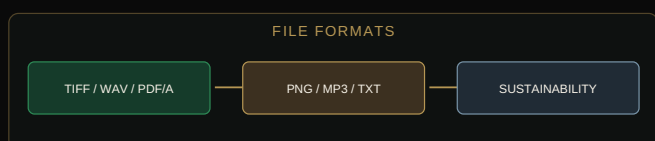
28. Metadata — archival framework.



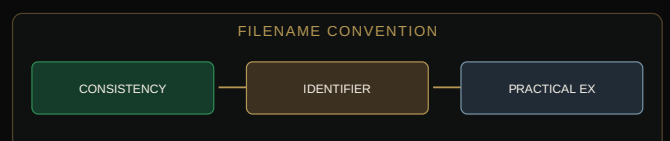
29. Metadata example — archival framework.



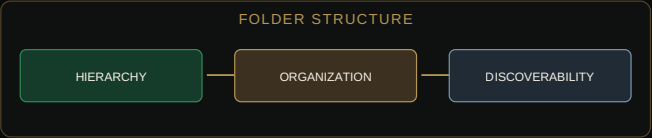
30. Digital files — archival framework.



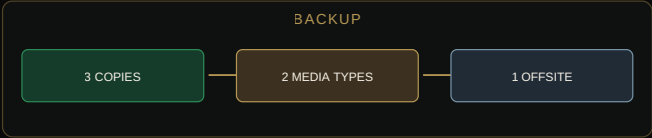
31. File formats — archival framework.



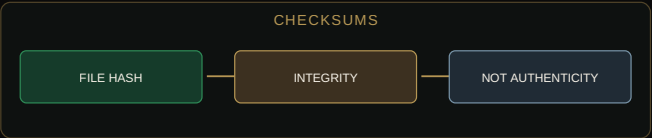
32. Filename convention — archival framework.



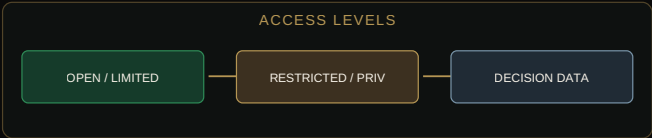
33. Folder structure — archival framework.



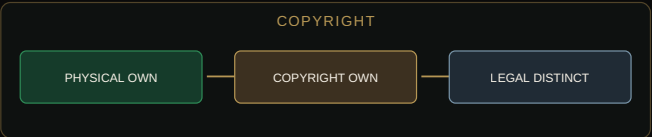
34. Backup — archival framework.



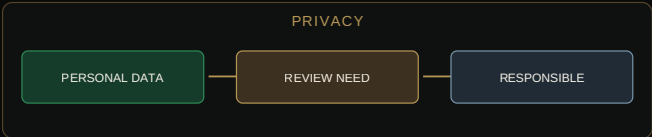
35. Checksums — archival framework.



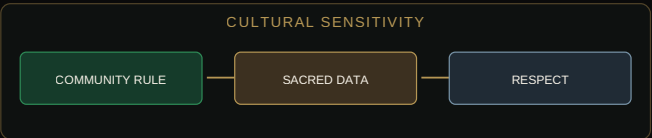
36. Access levels — archival framework.



37. Copyright — archival framework.



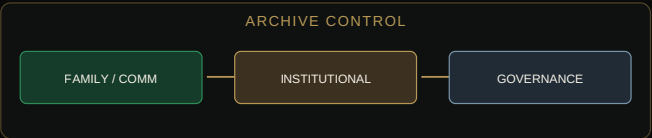
38. Privacy — archival framework.



39. Cultural sensitivity — archival framework.



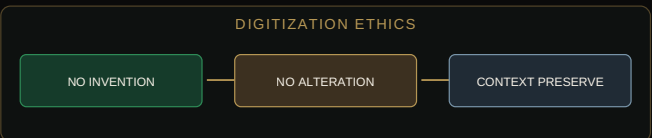
40. Community consent — archival framework.



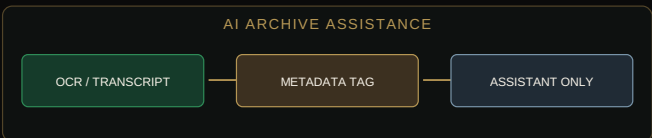
41. Archive control — archival framework.



42. Governance — archival framework.



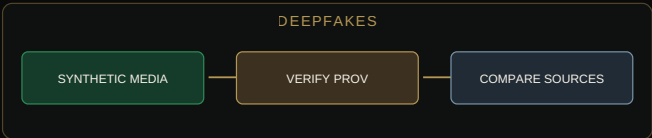
43. Digitization ethics — archival framework.



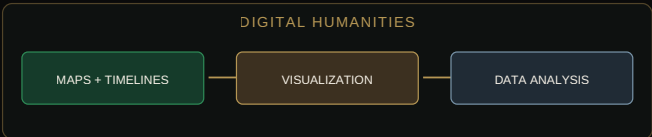
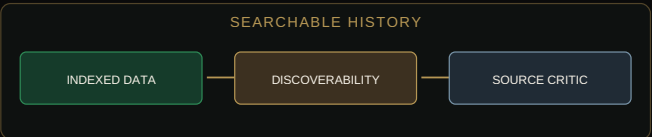
44. AI archive assistance — archival framework.



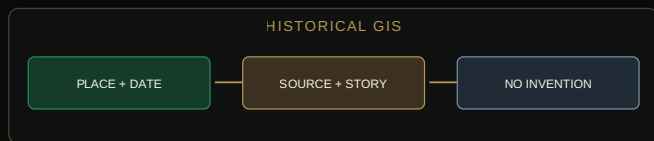
45. AI restoration — archival framework.



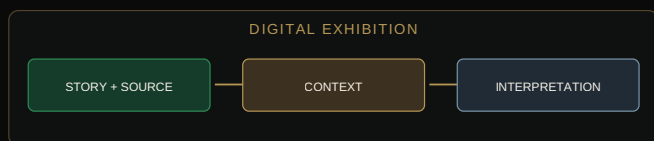
46. Deepfakes — archival framework.



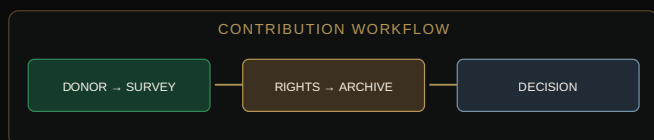
47. Searchable history — archival framework.



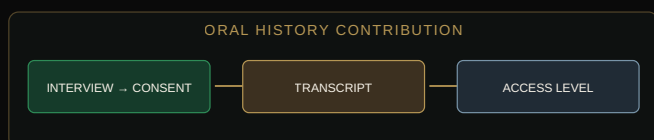
49. Historical GIS — archival framework.



51. Digital exhibition — archival framework.



53. Contribution workflow — archival framework.



55. Oral history contribution — archival framework.

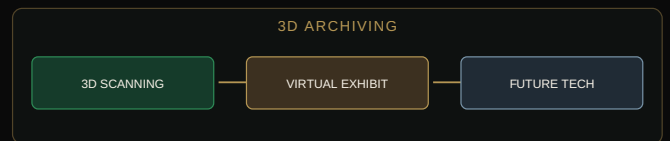


57. Archivist responsibility — archival framework.

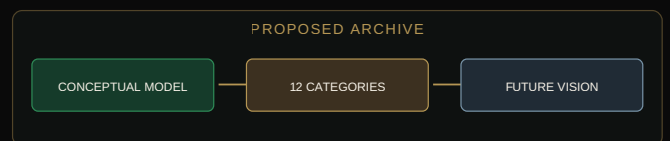


59. Future generations — archival framework.

48. Digital humanities — archival framework.



50. 3D archiving — archival framework.



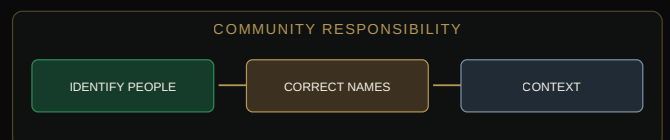
52. Proposed archive — archival framework.



54. Family donation — archival framework.



56. Researcher responsibility — archival framework.



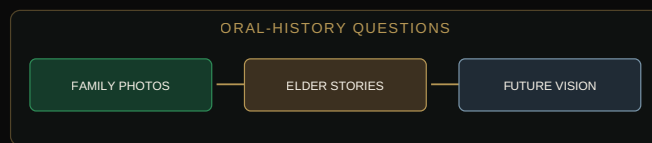
58. Community responsibility — archival framework.



60. Limitations — archival framework.



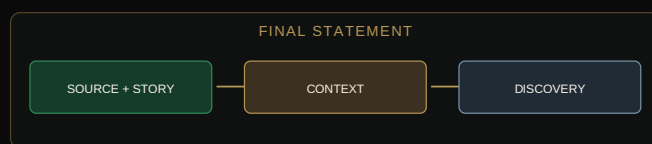
61. Research gap — archival framework.



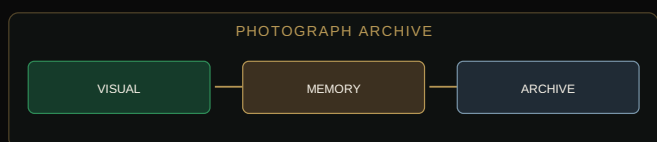
62. Oral-history questions — archival framework.



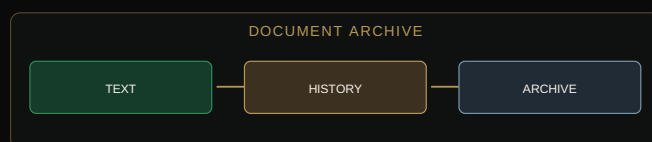
63. Author reflection — archival framework.



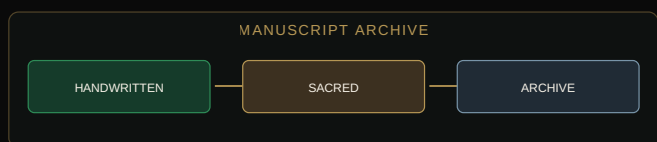
64. Final statement — archival framework.



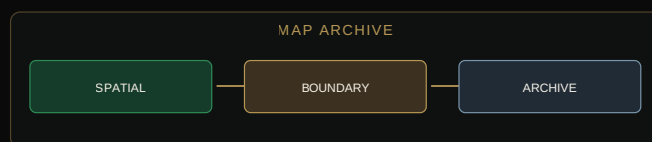
65. Photograph archive — archival framework.



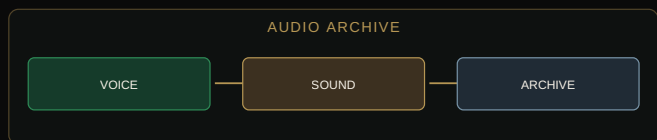
66. Document archive — archival framework.



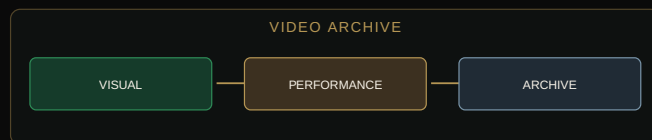
67. Manuscript archive — archival framework.



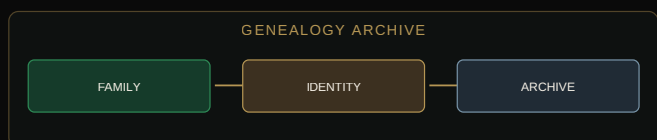
68. Map archive — archival framework.



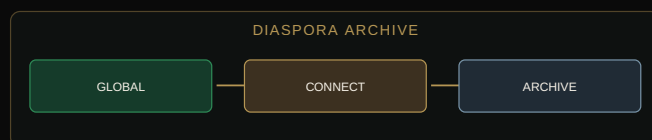
69. Audio archive — archival framework.



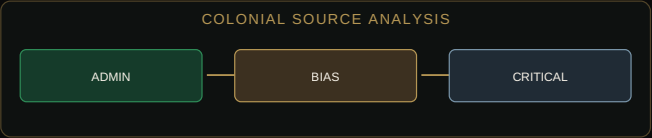
70. Video archive — archival framework.



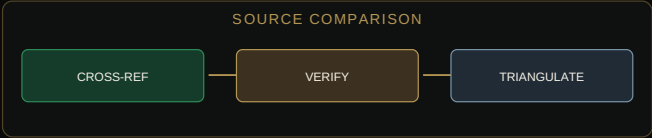
71. Genealogy archive — archival framework.



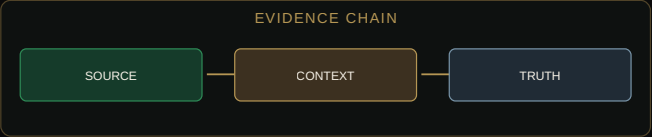
72. Diaspora archive — archival framework.



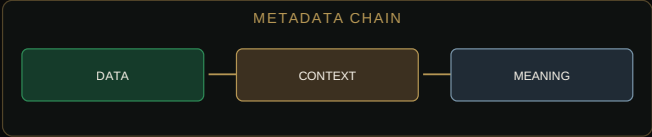
73. Colonial source analysis — archival framework.



74. Source comparison — archival framework.



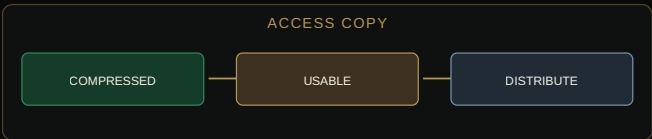
75. Evidence chain — archival framework.



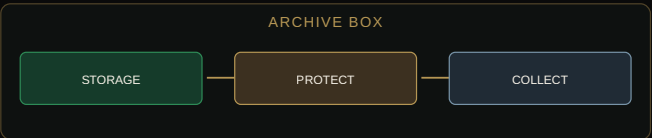
76. Metadata chain — archival framework.



77. Preservation master — archival framework.



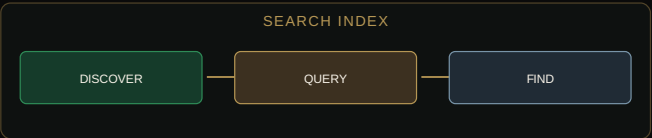
78. Access copy — archival framework.



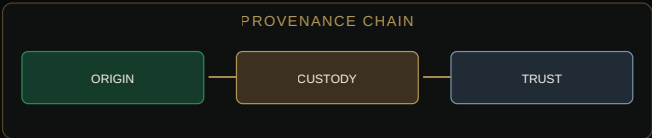
79. Archive box — archival framework.



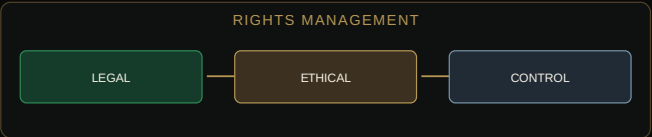
80. Digital repository — archival framework.



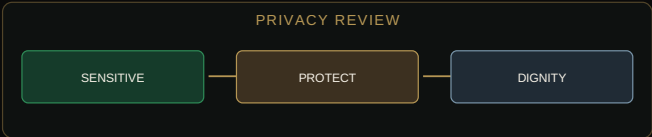
81. Search index — archival framework.



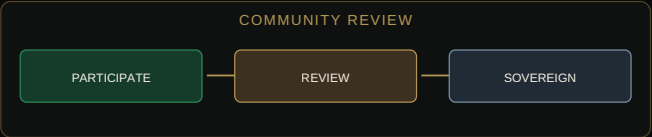
82. Provenance chain — archival framework.



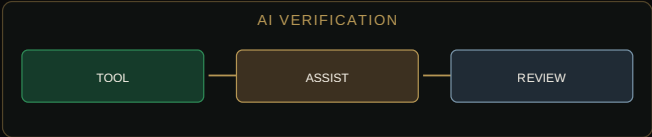
83. Rights management — archival framework.



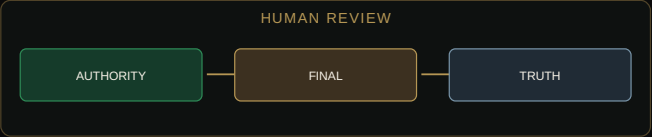
84. Privacy review — archival framework.



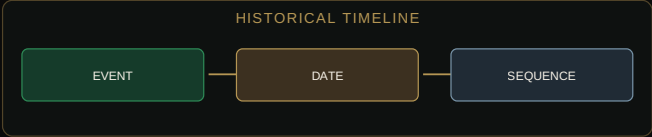
85. Community review — archival framework.



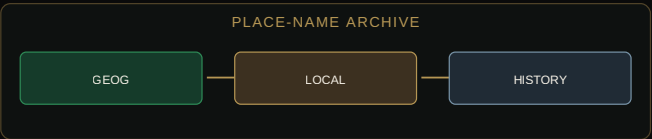
86. AI verification — archival framework.



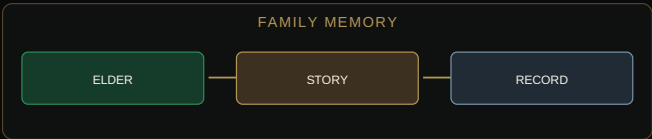
87. Human review — archival framework.



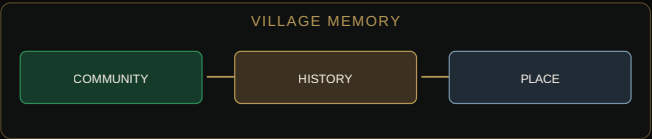
88. Historical timeline — archival framework.



89. Place-name archive — archival framework.



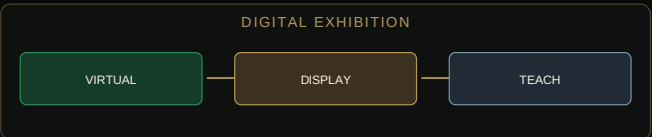
90. Family memory — archival framework.



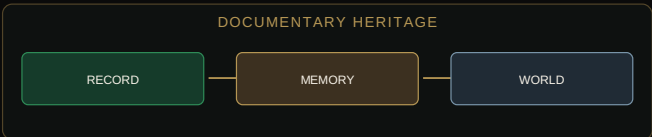
91. Village memory — archival framework.



92. Future researcher — archival framework.



93. Digital exhibition — archival framework.



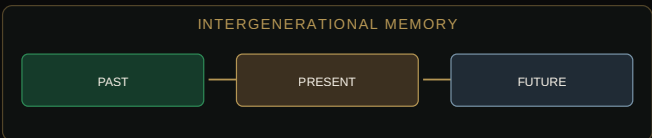
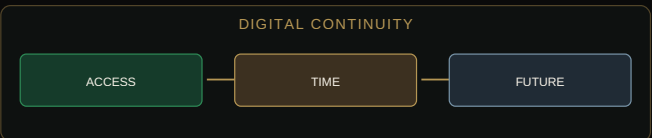
94. Documentary heritage — archival framework.



95. Preservation planning — archival framework.

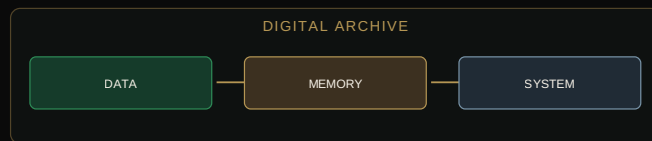
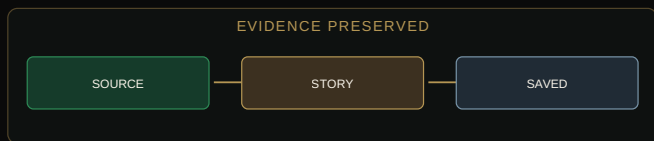


96. Archive risk — archival framework.



97. Digital continuity — archival framework.

98. Intergenerational memory — archival framework.



99. Evidence preserved — archival framework.

100. Digital archive — archival framework.

RESEARCH GAP: WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE DOCUMENTED

- Privately held Orakzai photographs
- Family document collections
- Village histories (unwritten)
- Historical maps (local/colonial)
- Manuscripts (religious/literary)
- Pashto recordings (dialects)
- Oral histories (elders/women)
- Migration and diaspora records
- Community and sports publications
- Traditional music and poetry
- Educational and school records
- Local place-name histories
- Colonial and post-1947 archives
- Digital preservation standards

“Before an archive can be digitized, someone must first discover that it exists.”

ORAL HISTORY QUESTIONS

1. What old documents does your family still have?
2. Who keeps them and where did they come from?
3. What stories are attached to family photographs?
4. Which recordings exist on old media (cassettes)?
5. Which documents relate to migration or land?
6. Which village histories are unwritten?
7. Which Pashto words appear in old records?
8. Who should control access to family records?
9. What material has already been lost?
10. What should future generations be able to search?

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

“An archive can begin with one photograph. One document. One voice. One family deciding that something should not be forgotten. For communities whose histories are

scattered across homes, institutions and generations, digitization can bring fragments together without requiring every original to leave the hands of the people who preserve it.

But technology should serve memory, not replace it. A scanner cannot explain a photograph. A database cannot know why a story matters. An algorithm cannot decide whether a private document should be public. Those decisions require people. They require context. They require consent. And they require respect for uncertainty.

If we digitize carefully, preserve the original, record provenance, protect privacy and allow communities to participate in the process, then scattered records can become a stronger historical resource. The goal is not to create a perfect archive. The goal is to make sure that evidence that can still be saved is not silently lost.”

DIGITIZE THE RECORD. PRESERVE ITS PROVENANCE. RESPECT ITS PEOPLE. LET THE FUTURE READ THE EVIDENCE.

RESEARCH SOURCES & FOOTNOTES

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